

Thursday, August 11

Peter began his day with cello practise. Cheryl took the boys to “Humpty Dumpty” for Kindergarten clothes. Peter got four shirts. I finished cleaning the basement and tended the yard.

Cheryl made another fruit salad. Before we ate, Maureen Bingham came over to get a blood sample from one of us for some control group in an arthritis experiment being run at the University Hospital. Cheryl gave it, poor girl. Maureen called me a wimp. I told her that the only reason a woman would do what Cheryl is doing is to become more like a man. Matthew showed Maureen his walk. She said, “That kid. He’s not walking. He’s not supposed to do that at ten months.” When she left the house was quiet.

The only thing Peter didn’t like about the salad was the zucchini. When Cheryl told him it was kiwi he said he didn’t like that either. I said there are apricots in there as well. He said he doesn’t like apricots. I said he didn’t know what an apricot tasted like. He held up a nectarine and asked if that was an apricot.

He won’t sit still on his chair. He pushes it back until only an edge is close enough to sit on. He slides back and away from the table; then he loses interest in the meal. He stands on the chair and talks, always talks, nibbles at a crust, runs around to Matthew’s chair to give him a hug and then excuses himself to the bathroom. Every meal this thin little boy burns more calories than he takes in.

The afternoon became a small disaster. Cheryl took Peter to his bike class on the way downtown. At 2:30 she phoned to see if I could pick Peter up since she was going to be a minute late looking over Matthew’s birthday gift with her mother (and Matthew). I said I would. At 2:40, five minutes before Peter’s class was finished, the Mazda wouldn’t start. Five minutes later it still wouldn’t start. I took my bike out of the basement and raced to the Field House. Peter was unconcerned by my late arrival. I thought we would wait a few minutes until Cheryl got home and then phone for a ride. By 4 we were still unable to contact her. Even though the wind blew strong from the Southeast, precisely the direction we had to travel, Peter and I headed to Weir Crescent. No-one was

home. We climbed the apple tree, ate some carrots and peas, chatted while standing on top of the doghouse (a Peter Rabbit adventure) and finally biked on to Preston and 8th. We phoned from a public booth. Cheryl was at home very worried and feeling to blame for the mix-up. I told her we had enjoyed ourselves.

We ate supper at Burger King and were home by 6. Peter and Erin played for a short time in the basement while I practised guitar. Cheryl was alone with Matthew in the kitchen, holding off him with one arm, mopping the floor with the other and saying,

“Back, back Matthew.”

He answered, “Back, back,” and tried to get past her hand into the film of water.

An active boy has become much more so now that he can walk. If a hand drifts by he will grab it and walk along. He turns corners then stands still, always a laugh to follow.

Both boys bathed at 7. We watched Cheers at 7:30 (Coach loses 8000 dollars to a hustler). The boys were in bed by 8. I lay with Peter. He asked about death and about all the people I knew who had died. For each story he would shake his head and say, “That’s really horrible.” He admitted to crying one night because he was afraid of dying.

Peter is doing mental arithmetic. While driving, Cheryl asked him addition questions, 3 plus 2, 4 plus 4. He provided the correct answer within an instant. Cheryl asked a few more. We told him that we were surprised.

He responded, “I have to think you know.”

When she gave him 4 plus 3 plus 2, he said, “That makes me think too hard. I want to make you think. What’s 200 and 100 and 300?”

Cheryl knitted Dawn’s sweater. I read The Rainbow until 9:30. We watched Three’s Company. At 10 Cheryl talked with her mother on the phone and then went to bed.